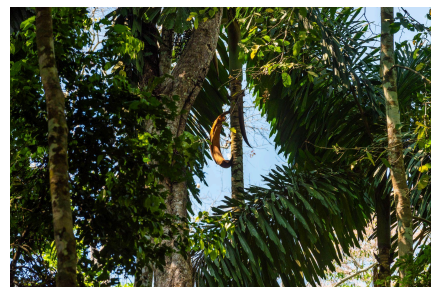
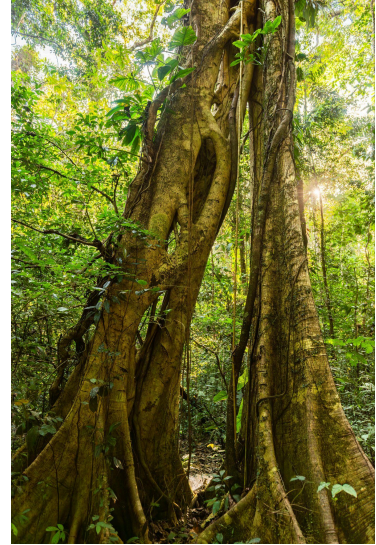


But in this jungle, where there is growth, there is also destruction. Among epiphytes, strangler figs are the rainforest's executioners. Their seeds are often carried by birds to the tops of tall trees, where they germinate in tiny crevices. Their roots grow downward, touch the ground, thicken, and begin wrapping around the host tree. Over time, they tighten their grip until the host suffocates, leaving behind only a hollow shell—a suspended tombstone.

Cruel as it sounds, the strangler fig is simply fulfilling its role in maintaining ecological balance. And when it finally topples after losing its support, the newly opened space offers another chance for life to begin again.

Over millions of years, the Amazon has evolved countless unique plants, and through generations of observation, Indigenous communities have discovered their uses. Our guide, Elder, knew every one of them by heart:



- Sangapilla's crushed leaves release a purple-red dye that also works as an antiseptic.
- Cordonsillo leaves numb your mouth when chewed—a natural anesthetic once used for tooth extractions.
- Baka bamboo serves as a natural water pipe and can also be used as a container for roasting fish.
- The spikes on huicungo palm trunks are used to make blow darts.
- Palm leaves are strong enough to be woven into ropes and shoe soles.
- Rubber trees release a milky latex that is used to make waterproof clothing.
- Dragon's blood trees produce a red sap that can be used to treat stomach ulcers.